

Turkish integration in Germany

To what extent have Turkish immigrants integrated in Germany and what challenges do they face?

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COR359

I. Abstract

This research paper will explore how Turkish immigrants live in Germany and how well they have integrated. To achieve this, the paper will first provide a history on Turkish immigration into Germany before looking at some of the challenges they face, as well as touching on what Turkish religious life and culture looks like in Germany today.

II. Introduction

Numerous changes toward the end of the twentieth century served as a driving force for not just economic migration, but also the search for a better life, free from political violence. One of the reasons that migrants were drawn to Germany was its receptiveness. Whereas East Germany remained closed under the rule of socialism, West Germany turned into a country of immigration against its will, due to its policy of admitting asylum seekers and recruiting foreign labor for its post-war rebuilding efforts (Horrocks, 2001, 73). The former policy was an attempt by Germany to distance itself from its Nazi past (Horrocks, 2011, 73). Foreign labor on the other hand seemed like the easiest solution to attain the necessary workforce to rebuild a war-torn country (Klüsener, 2006, 3).

Immigrants with a Turkish background represent the biggest minority group in Germany, accounting for nearly 3 million of the more than 80 million people living there, according to the 2011 census. A recent article by DW stated that of those 3 million Turks now living in Germany, a majority feels more connected to Turkey than Germany (Deutsche Welle, 2018). This raises the question of the extent to which Turkish immigrants have integrated into German society. In order to approach this question, the following section will provide an overview of the history of Turkish migration to Germany.

III. History of Turkish immigration into Germany

It is notable that Turks did not have a history of migration. There was no sense of readiness to leave their homeland or to seek a different or better life. The surge in Turkish migration came after the 1950s, when postwar Europe was in the midst of its rebuilding efforts. Germany became a goal for these Turkish migrants for historical reasons. Imperial Germany had influence on certain Turkish zones, Prussians were trained in Ottoman military schools and Turkey and Germany were both allies during World War I (Abadan-Unat, 2011, xxiv).

At this point, Turkish immigration into Germany was the result of the capitalist system. It can roughly be divided into three phases, starting with Germany's labor shortage in the 1950s. For its rebuilding efforts, they sought workers, but with the expectation that they would return to their home country once the work was done. Turkish state planners, on the other hand, were looking for a short-term solution to their economic problems. Hence, each party had what the other needed. To prevent permanent settlement, Turkish workers arrived within the framework of a

“guest-worker system.” This placed restrictions on political participation and excluded them from unemployment pay. Religious freedom was not restricted. It was encouraged. The reasoning was that it would be easier for guest workers to re-integrate into their original societies if they maintained a connection to it, be it through religious or other means (Caesar, 2013, 4-5).

Following the oil crisis in 1973, growing unemployment forced Germany and other European governments to stop recruiting foreign labor. This can be seen as the beginning of the second phase and caused disagreements over how to treat the Turkish and other migrant workers. The Union of German Employers wanted the guest workers to return home to prevent public services from becoming overloaded, while the Confederation of German Unions pleaded for integration (Abadan-Unat, 2011, 13-14). Despite the ban on foreign labor recruitment, the number of migrants actually increased because they decided to bring their families with them rather than return home. The third phase following this new influx in the 80s and 90s began with the government of Angela Merkel and revolved around finding ways to integrate the migrant workers into society (Yurdakul, 2009, xiiv). After discussing the history of Turkish migration to Germany, the following paragraph will focus on what that migration experience was like.

IV. Migration experience

Experiences of life after moving to Germany can vary drastically depending on one’s background. “Personal socialisation, opportunities, experiences, motives and perspectives,” all play a part of the post-immigration experience according to Horrocks. The typical *Gastarbeiter* (guest worker) experience for first generation Turkish migrants was captured in Güney Dal’s

novel *Wenn Ali die Glocken läuten hört* (When Ali hears the bells ringing, 1979). Common themes included hostel life, isolation, confusion by a foreign language and culture, prejudice and racism on a regular basis, high levels of stress and corruption of traditional values. The book's focus on three migrants working in contrasting fields (a student, factory worker and laboratory assistant) also helps explain the deep divisions in the Turkish community in Germany. The novel also draws a picture of how disadvantaged Germans viewed the Turks – “as ugly, loud and garishly dressed, dragging swarms of children, ‘a rapidly spreading epidemic,’” (Horrocks, 1996, 7-8). These negative perceptions mostly relate to the days when Turks were primarily seen as foreign labor workers, but controversies and challenges are still present in Turkish communities in Germany. One of the big challenges in regards to cultural integration, which will be further explained in the following lines, surrounds the headscarf.

V. The headscarf debate and Turkish-German tensions

The September 11 attacks affected not just the U.S., but also stirred up tensions between Muslim associations and German state authorities, resulting in more scrutiny from the state. Central to the debate was the removal of the Islamic headscarf from public places. Non-religious and religious associations have had varying stances on the issue. According to certain religious organizations, such as *Millî Görüş*, there should be no restrictions on exercising your religion in public (Yurdakul, 2009, 92). In 2018, a Muslim woman working as a cashier at *Müller* was threatened to be fired for wearing the headscarf. The court decided in her favor and the

organization now urges women to take similar cases to court (Islamische Gemeinschaft Millî Görüş, 2018).

The *Diyanet*, another religious association, downplayed the importance of the headscarf in Germany. They did this to prevent any troubles with German state authorities. Nevertheless, 65 Islamic organizations made their support of the headscarf clear in 2004, the Diyanet not among them. This placed them under President Bush's category of "good Muslims," which he had created to distinguish Muslims who were against terrorist attacks and sided with western countries. Millî Görüş inevitably branded themselves as "bad Muslims" after voicing support for the headscarf (Yurdakul. 2009, 93).

Another organization, *Türkischer Bund Berlin-Brandenburg* (or TBB), further distinguished between the headscarf and the hijab. The former has a loose knot under the chin and leaves out some of the front hair. The latter leaves no hair out and is tightly wrapped around the chin. The hijab is a conservative and political symbol and must be eliminated from public spaces according to the TBB, whereas the regular headscarf is acceptable for bridging cultures (Yurdakul. 2009, 93). That culture has been shaped both by Turkish and German elements, but Islam still remains a differentiating factor for both people. The next section of this paper will describe religion in the context of Turkish-Germans.

VI. Turkish-German Muslim culture

Due to the large number of Turkish immigrants in Germany, both cultures have strongly influenced each other. German-Turks are an active section of the German population. They have

established more than 60,000 businesses in the catering industries, retail and trade and the services sector. (Kaya, 2009, 52) Although Germany has seemingly provided a space for economic prosperity, the one thing it does not offer is a space to practice Islam, socialize and pray. That is why religious associations are popular with Turkish immigrants in Germany (Haddad, 2002, 164).

Two examples of such associations are the *Diyanet İşleri Türk-İslam Birliği*, supported by the German and Turkish state, and the *Islamische Gemeinschaft Millî Görüş*. Both are major Turkish religious associations, but have different ideologies. They share the goal of providing religious services to Turkish immigrants in Germany. Millî Görüş tries to engage with German society and one of its prominent members, Mustafa Yoldas, explained his view on integration as following:

“We have no problem about integration. However, many politicians expect assimilation instead of integration. I will tell you the difference. If integration is contributing to this society and being socially engaged with it, I am well-advanced in integration. [...] But if what you want is to dye our hair blonde, wear blue contact lenses, then drink *Hopfenbier*, eat *Bratwurst* and sing *Deutsche Volkslieder*, then you have to wait for a couple of centuries. I don't think this is going to happen (Yurdakul, 2009, 95-96).

Diyanet separates religion from politics and takes a more structured approach. It sees Muslim life as a cultural difference between the majority and the Muslims. Yurdakul states that both speak about their integration policies as a vision, rather than a practice, so they are unlikely to become a reality any time soon.

VII. Conclusion

In conclusion, any integration problems can be traced back the Germany's initial expectation in regards to foreign labor. They anticipated a temporary stay, so for decades, the government did little to address the Turkish workers who decided to stay permanently instead of returning to their home country. It wasn't until Angela Merkel that cultural integration became a goal. Even then, integration can be understood in different ways, with some Germans expecting something along the lines of complete rejection of heritage, in favor of German culture, traditions and behaviors. Therefore, it appears that Turkish integration in Germany is more so the result of tolerance, rather than active mixing of cultures. Even so, Merkel said in 2010 that multiculturalism had "utterly failed," so it is uncertain how Germany will approach the issue in the future (The Guardian, 2010).

VIII. Bibliography

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